

E011

Technical Communication

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

Method © 2026 Erik Daniel Lindquist — Course Mastery Coach, armored drill. Items drafted with AI assistance under his direction.

How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer _____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
-----------------------------	---	------------------------	----------------------------------

Items

1.

An IT manager is announcing a move to a new cloud email platform. The migration cost \$85,000, and the project team built its diagrams in a new architecture tool. The announcement goes to all 600 staff, most of them nontechnical. What should it focus on?

- A. A breakdown of the \$85,000 budget.
- B. One identical message for every audience, since good writing works for anyone.
- C. What changes for staff, when it happens, and what they need to do.
- D. The DNS record changes and the architecture diagram.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

For the same email migration, the manager now writes for the server administrators who will perform the cutover. What should their document contain?

- A. The business case and budget justification.
- B. A short, friendly note on what changes for them as users.
- C. A promotional announcement with benefits and a launch date.
- D. Technical steps, configuration details, timing, and a rollback plan.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

An IT lead needs the CFO, who joined the company eight months ago, to approve \$40,000 for backup storage before the quarter ends. The vendor's quote is 12 pages long. How should the email be structured?

- A. Start with the history of the backup system and end with the request.
- B. State the request, amount, and deadline first, then the key reasons.
- C. Attach the 12-page quote with no summary.
- D. Leave out all numbers, since executives never want figures in email.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

An engineer's report for executives puts the recommendation on page 9, after the background, method, and data sections. What is the best fix?

- A.** Add more background so the recommendation feels earned.
- B.** Move the recommendation to the top, in an opening summary.
- C.** Add a table of contents and leave the order unchanged.
- D.** Increase the font size of page 9.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

The help desk handled 1,300 tickets last quarter, many from staff who needed to reset their multifactor authentication device. The company style guide uses blue headings. Staff should be able to do this themselves. Which document fits best?

- A.** A report on the benefits of multifactor authentication.
- B.** A short procedure with numbered steps and screenshots.
- C.** A slide presentation.
- D.** A narrative paragraph formatted with blue headings.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

A guide for the Denver office's 20-person finance team, printed on letter-size paper, reads: "3. Unplug the server. Warning: save all open work first or data will be lost." What is the best revision?

- A.** Place the warning before step 3, ahead of the action.
- B.** Merge steps 2 through 4 into one paragraph.
- C.** Keep it as is, since readers always read the whole step before acting.
- D.** Bold the warning but leave it after the action.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which is the best-written procedure step?

- A.** Click Save.
- B.** Click Save, then Print, then Close, then sign out.
- C.** The Save button should be clicked by the user.
- D.** Save may need to be clicked, depending on settings.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

The procurement team, which meets on Thursdays, wants to compare three laptop models across six specifications: price, battery life, weight, memory, storage, and warranty. All three come in silver. Which visual fits best?

- A. A line chart.
- B. A pie chart.
- C. A comparison table.
- D. A photo of each silver laptop.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A manager wants a visual showing the steps and yes/no decision points a change request passes through before approval. Which fits best?

- A. A table.
- B. A written paragraph.
- C. A bar chart.
- D. A flowchart.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

A policy drafted by the legal team and posted on the intranet reads: “Utilization of the VPN is mandated by the organization for remote connectivity.” Which revision is clearest for general staff?

- A. “Remote connectivity mandates VPN utilization.”
- B. “The VPN must be utilized by all personnel for remote connectivity.”
- C. “Per the legal team’s intranet posting, VPN utilization is mandatory.”
- D. “You must use the VPN when you work remotely.”

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A 30-page network assessment took six weeks and covered four buildings. What belongs in its executive summary?

- A.** The key findings, the recommendation, and its cost and impact.
- B.** The methodology and scanning tools used.
- C.** A preview saying the details follow in the report.
- D.** A week-by-week timeline of the six-week assessment.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

A presenter will brief 25 department heads using the meeting room’s new projector. One slide has 180 words in eight bullet points, and the presenter plans to read it aloud. What is the best fix?

- A.** Keep the text and read it faster.
- B.** Never put any text on slides.
- C.** Use a headline stating the main message with a simple visual; move detail to notes or a handout.
- D.** Shrink the font so all 180 words fit comfortably.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer C Concept 1

An IT manager is announcing a move to a new cloud email platform. ~~The migration cost \$85,000, and the project team built its diagrams in a new architecture tool.~~ The announcement goes to all 600 staff, most of them nontechnical. What should it focus on?

Target word: content for a nontechnical audience **Decides:** Readers are all staff who need to know what changes for them.

A	Camouflage	Cost does not help staff prepare for the change.
B	Absolute language	Different audiences need different content.
C	Correct	Matches the readers' needs and actions.
D	Adjacent category	Useful to technical staff, not to general users.

2. Answer D Concept 1 • transfer

For the same email migration, the manager now writes for the server administrators who will perform the cutover. What should their document contain?

Target word: content for a technical audience — reverse of the all-staff item **Decides:** Readers will execute the technical work.

A	Adjacent category	Useful to approvers, not to the people doing the cutover.
B	Inverted operation	That is the all-staff message, not the admins' task.
C	Confusion set	Marketing tone gives admins nothing to act on.
D	Correct	Admins need precise, actionable technical detail.

3. Answer B Concept 2

An IT lead needs the CFO, ~~who joined the company eight months ago,~~ to approve \$40,000 for backup storage before the quarter ends. ~~The vendor's quote is 12 pages long.~~ How should the email be structured?

Target word: structure for a decision request **Decides:** The reader must approve something by a deadline.

A	Inverted operation	Buries the decision at the end.
B	Correct	Bottom line up front lets the executive decide quickly.
C	Camouflage	Quote length does not help structure the ask.
D	Absolute language	The amount is central to the decision.

4. Answer B Concept 2 • transfer

An engineer's report for executives puts the recommendation on page 9, after the background, method, and data sections. What is the best fix?

Target word: fix a buried conclusion **Decides:** The decision-maker has to dig for the point.

A	Inverted operation	Pushes the point even further back.
B	Correct	Puts the bottom line up front for decision-makers.
C	Dropped element	Helps navigation but leaves the point buried.
D	Confusion set	Formatting does not change where the reader meets the point.

5. Answer B Concept 3

The help desk handled 1,300 tickets last quarter, many from staff who needed to reset their multifactor authentication device. The company style guide uses blue headings. Staff should be able to do this themselves. Which document fits best?

Target word: document type **Decides:** Readers need to perform a task.

A	Adjacent category	Explains why, not how to do the reset.
B	Correct	Procedures are built for readers who must act.
C	Confusion set	Slides support a speaker; they are poor standalone instructions.
D	Camouflage	Style-guide color does not make prose usable as steps.

6. Answer A Concept 4

A guide for the Denver office's 20-person finance team, printed on letter-size paper, reads: "3. Unplug the server. Warning: save all open work first or data will be lost." What is the best revision?

Target word: fix the warning placement **Decides:** The warning comes after the risky action.

A	Correct	Readers act as they read; warnings must come first.
B	Inverted operation	Makes the procedure harder to follow.
C	Absolute language	Many readers act on the first instruction they see.
D	Dropped element	More visible, but still after the risky step.

7. Answer A Concept 4 · transfer

Which is the best-written procedure step?

Target word: pick the well-formed step **Decides:** One action, imperative voice.

A	Correct	Direct, imperative, one action.
B	Adjacent category	Packs four actions into one step.
C	Inverted operation	Passive voice hides who acts and adds words.
D	Confusion set	Hedging leaves readers unsure whether to act.

8. Answer C Concept 5

The procurement team, which meets on Thursdays, wants to compare three laptop models across six specifications: price, battery life, weight, memory, storage, and warranty. All three come in silver. Which visual fits best?

Target word: visual for multi-attribute comparison **Decides:** Exact values across many attributes.

A	Inverted operation	Line charts show change over time, which is not in the data.
B	Confusion set	Pie charts show parts of one whole.
C	Correct	Tables show exact values side by side.
D	Camouflage	Color does not help compare specifications.

9. Answer D Concept 5 • transfer

A manager wants a visual showing the steps and yes/no decision points a change request passes through before approval. Which fits best?

Target word: visual for a process **Decides:** Sequence plus decisions.

A	Adjacent category	Tables compare values but do not show flow.
B	Dropped element	Drops the visual; decision branches are hard to follow in prose.
C	Confusion set	Bar charts compare quantities, not steps.
D	Correct	Flowcharts show steps and branching decisions.

10. Answer D Concept 6

A policy ~~drafted by the legal team and posted on the intranet~~ reads: "Utilization of the VPN is mandated by the organization for remote connectivity." Which revision is clearest for general staff?

Target word: plain-language rewrite **Decides:** Active voice, "you," common words.

A	Confusion set	Shorter but more abstract; it hides who must act.
B	Dropped element	Still passive and full of formal jargon.
C	Camouflage	Adds the source detail without making the rule clearer.
D	Correct	Short, active, and speaks to the reader.

11. Answer A Concept 7

A 30-page network assessment ~~took six weeks and covered four buildings~~. What belongs in its executive summary?

Target word: content of an executive summary **Decides:** It must stand alone for a decision-maker.

A	Correct	A reader can act on the summary without the full report.
B	Adjacent category	Belongs in the methods section.
C	Dropped element	Drops the findings; it cannot stand alone.
D	Camouflage	Duration details do not help the decision.

12. Answer C Concept 8

A presenter will brief ~~25 department heads using the meeting room's new projector~~. One slide has 180 words in eight bullet points, and the presenter plans to read it aloud. What is the best fix?

Target word: fix a text-heavy slide **Decides:** The slide competes with the speaker.

A	Dropped element	Drops the real problem of too much text.
B	Absolute language	A short headline and labels help the audience.
C	Correct	Slides support the speaker; detail belongs elsewhere.
D	Inverted operation	Makes the slide denser and harder to read.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	6	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	6	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	7	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	4	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	7	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	6	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Audience analysis	Content, detail, and vocabulary depend on who will read it and what they need to do.	Writing one version for everyone, or giving nontechnical readers the technical detail.	A named audience with a clear role (all staff, admins, executives).
2	Bottom line up front	For decision-makers, lead with the conclusion or request, then support it.	Building up chronologically to the point on the last page.	An executive who must approve or decide.
3	Choosing the document type	Match the genre to the reader's task: procedures for doing, reports for deciding, references for looking up.	Writing a report or slide deck when the reader needs to perform steps.	"Staff need to do X themselves."
4	Writing procedures	Use numbered steps, one action per step, imperative verbs, and put warnings before the step they apply to.	Passive, hedged steps or warnings placed after the risky action.	A step list with a caution or several actions in one step.
5	Matching the visual to the data	Tables show exact values across many attributes; flowcharts show steps and decisions; line charts show trends over time.	Picking a chart type that cannot show the relationship.	"Compare specs" vs. "show the approval path" vs. "show the trend."
6	Plain language	Use active voice, the reader as "you," common words, and short sentences.	Nominalized, passive, jargon-heavy phrasing that sounds formal.	Words like "utilization," "mandated," and "by the user."
7	Executive summary	It stands alone: key findings, recommendation, and impact in brief, readable without the full report.	Filling it with methods or a teaser for later sections.	"What belongs in the executive summary?"
8	Slides support the speaker	One main message per slide, a headline that states it, and minimal text; detail goes in notes or handouts.	Dense text slides read aloud, or shrinking fonts to fit more.	A slide with many bullets being read word for word.

Course scope (public description): Technical Communication teaches IT managers how to convey complex information clearly and effectively to diverse audiences, whether technical or nontechnical. The course covers skills in writing, presentation, and visual communication, enabling managers to create documentation, reports, and presentations that are precise and accessible. Additionally, it emphasizes audience analysis, which helps managers tailor their messages to stakeholders, enhancing project understanding and decision-making across teams. There are no prerequisites for this course.